caves. The monastery was founded in the fifteenth century as a Sharana (Shiva devotee) abode for spreading the teachings of the twelfth-century Lingayat statesman-saint-social reformer Basavanna. As a centre for Sharana Sahitya (literature) and 'Shunya Sampadane' (an anthology of Kannada poems by several medieval Lingayat saints), it developed as a critical node for the Bhakti movement during the time of the Vijayanagar empire. Located in Karnataka's Tumkur district, it is also home to a gurukul (traditional school) that provides education, free food and shelter to over 10,000 poor children.[3]

The Siddaganga Math became the epicentre of a heated political exchange in the summer of 2018 when the then Congress Chief Minister Siddaramaiah tried to reduce the BJP's recent dominance among Lingayat voters by recommending minority status for the sect.[4] This meant that the Lingayats would be recognised as a distinct religious community, outside of Hinduism, and be eligible for reservation benefits as a minority community under state laws. While many Lingayats also call themselves Veerashaivas,[5] the cabinet order simultaneously recognised Veerashaiva-Lingayats as a separate Lingayat subsect, opening up another contentious religious argument.[6] 'The government is dividing us. Mark my words, this move has changed the election. Lingayats will not forgive Congress for this,' T.B. Shekhar, the agitated head of the Tumkur Veerashaiva Samaj, told me during a live video discussion in the Math's courtyard on 6 May 2018, as we tried to make sense of Karnataka's caste matrix. State assembly elections were due a week later, and we had travelled to Tumkur for a broadcast on how Lingayat voters viewed the poll campaign.

As we talked in the afternoon sun, the then presiding seer of the Math, the legendary 112-year-old Shivakumar Swamiji, stepped out. Locally known as 'Nadedaaduva Devaru' (Walking God), he had come out to the courtyard, dressed in his customary saffron robes, to give 'darshan' despite his ill-health. He sat on his sanctified 'aasan' with its finely carved Shivling on a polished wooden panel. Swamiji's appearance electrified the hundreds of devotees standing around us, all of whom instantly queued up for their turn to touch his feet.[7]